

LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 1–2 · 35 minutes · Read-aloud + centers

THE 35 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	5 min	12 min	3 min
HOOK	READ-ALOUD	ART LOOK	ACTIVITY CARDS	SHARE

SESSION GOALS

What students will do

Students will: understand that the Harlem Renaissance was a time when Black artists, musicians, and writers created amazing work together; identify key vocabulary (jazz, poetry, silhouette, Great Migration); practice close observation of visual art; and make personal connections through writing and drawing.

PREPARATION

- **Display:** *Song of the Towers* or *Aspects of Negro Life* print or projection
- **Tables set:** differentiated activity cards (Green / Yellow / Red), pencils, crayons
- **Read-aloud prepared:** *Harlem* by Walter Dean Myers (1997) — ideal anchor text; *Jazz* by Walter Dean Myers also excellent

SESSION FLOW

0–5 MIN Hook	Play 20 seconds of Duke Ellington. Ask: *"What do you picture in your mind when you hear this music? What colors? What movements?"* Take 4 responses. *"This music comes from Harlem, New York, about 100 years ago. Today we're going on a visit."*
5–15 MIN Read-aloud	Read *Harlem* by Walter Dean Myers. Pause at 3–4 spreads to ask: *"What do you notice? What words sound like music? What feelings are here?"* After reading: *"The words in that book were written by a poet — someone whose job is to put the world into the most powerful words possible. Langston Hughes did the same thing in the 1920s."*
15–20 MIN Art look	Display Aaron Douglas. Quick 5-question look: What do you see? What do the circles make you think of? Why no faces? What colors? If you could hear this painting, what would it sound like?
20–32 MIN Activity cards	Students work independently or in pairs on differentiated cards. Circulate and conference with at least 3–4 students. Encourage going beyond minimum responses.
32–35 MIN Share	One student from each level shares. Close: *"You've just spent time with artists who lived 100 years ago. Their work was so good it still makes us feel something today. That's what great art does."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more.

Option 2 — Virtual Visit:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS · GRADES 1–2

ANCHOR TEXTS

Harlem — Walter Dean Myers / Christopher Myers (1997) — Caldecott Honor; the essential Grades 1–2 Harlem text

Jazz — Walter Dean Myers (2006) — stunning visual poetry about jazz

A Sweet Smell of Roses — Angela Johnson — civil rights context, accessible

SUPPORTING READS

Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes — selected and illustrated edition; ideal for read-aloud

Let the Children March — Monica Clark-Robinson — civil rights, age-appropriate

Aaron Douglas artist profile cards — printable from museum education sites

DIFFERENTIATION NOTES

At this level, the Green/Yellow/Red split primarily reflects reading scaffolding and writing expectation depth rather than topic difficulty. All students engage with the same art and same core ideas — the differentiation is in how much independent language production is expected. Red-level students at Grades 1–2 are ready for genuine critical thinking: asking *why*, not just *what*.

DISPLAY SUGGESTIONS

- **Feature display:** Harlem Renaissance portraits — use library display boards to show Douglas, Hughes, Ellington, Hurston, McKay with brief bios at 1–2 grade reading level
- **Student work wall:** post silhouette drawings from the session alongside the Douglas print
- **Book spine display:** all Harlem Renaissance-related books face-out for the duration of the unit

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Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934) · The Creation (1935)